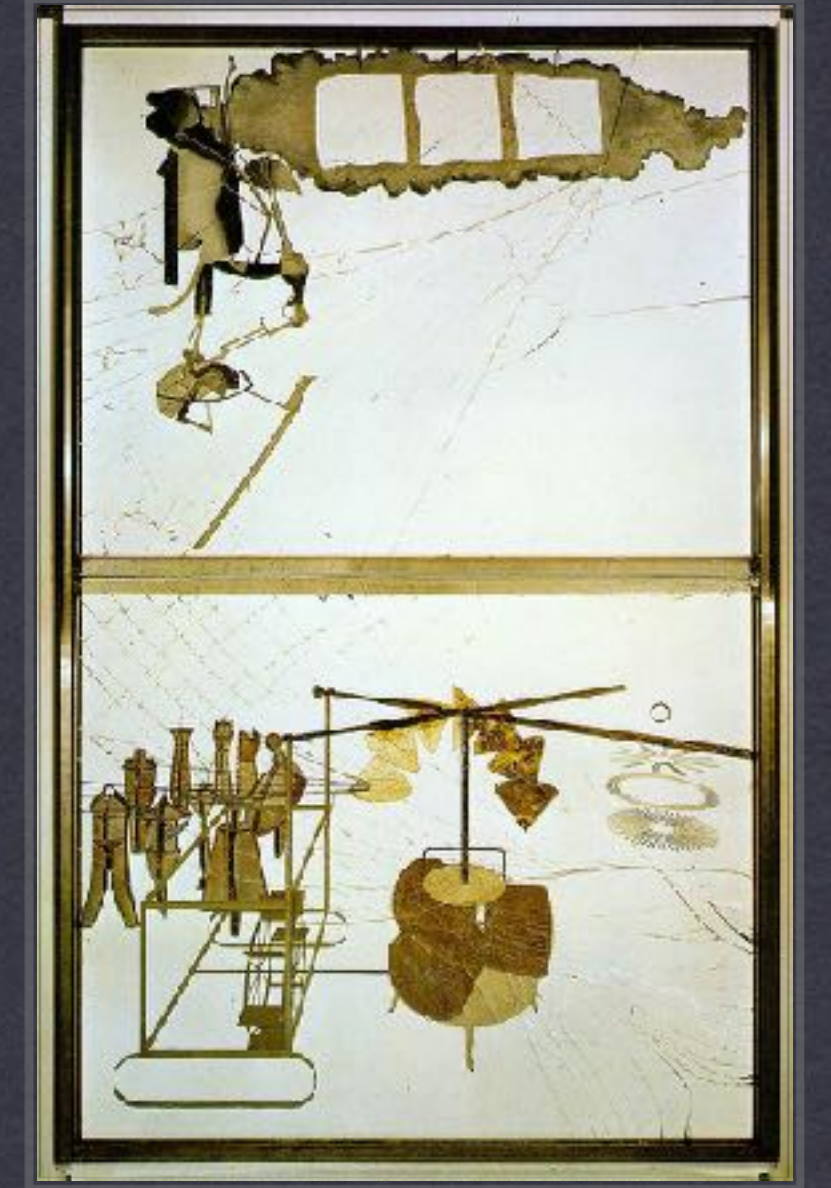
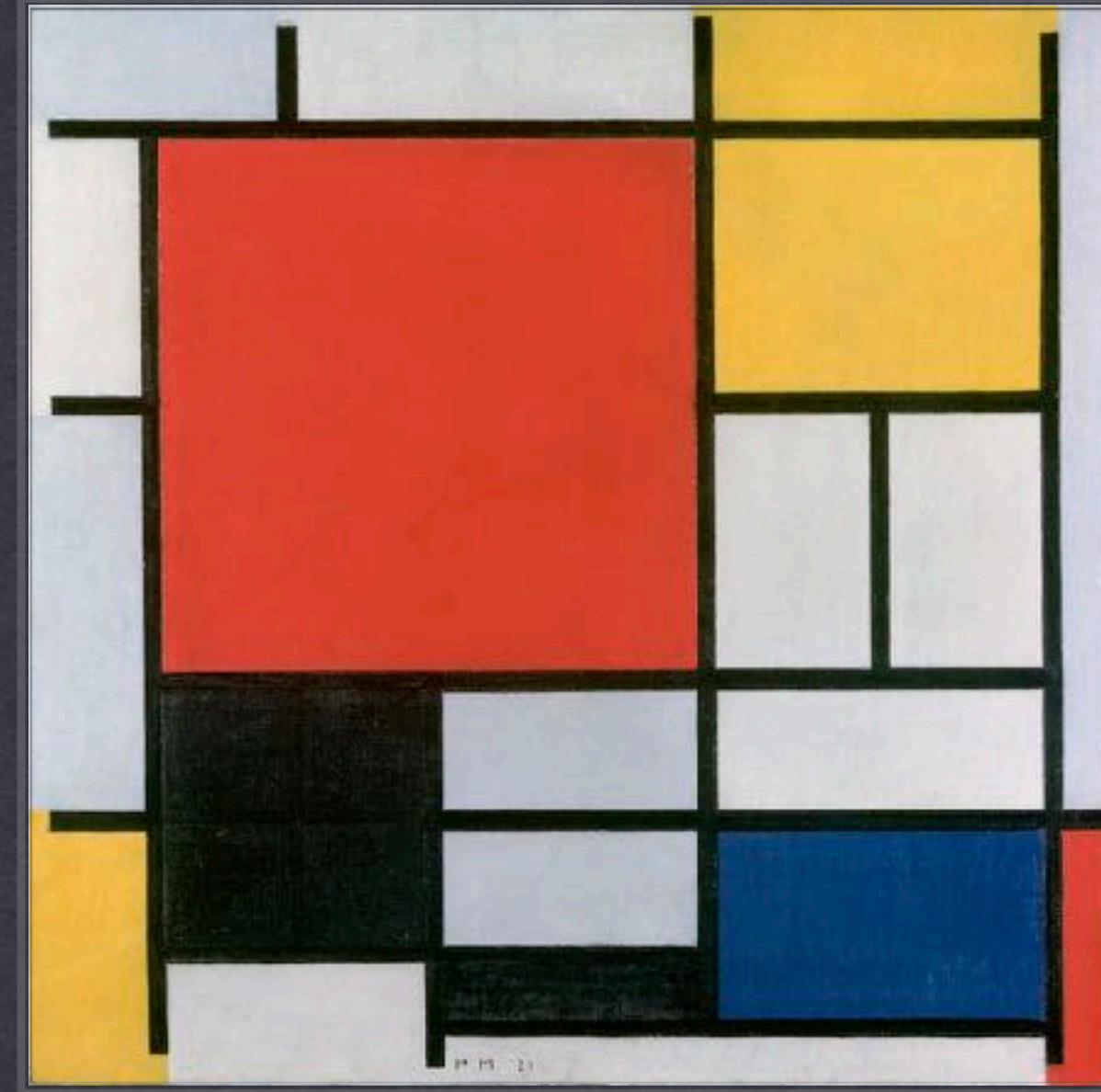
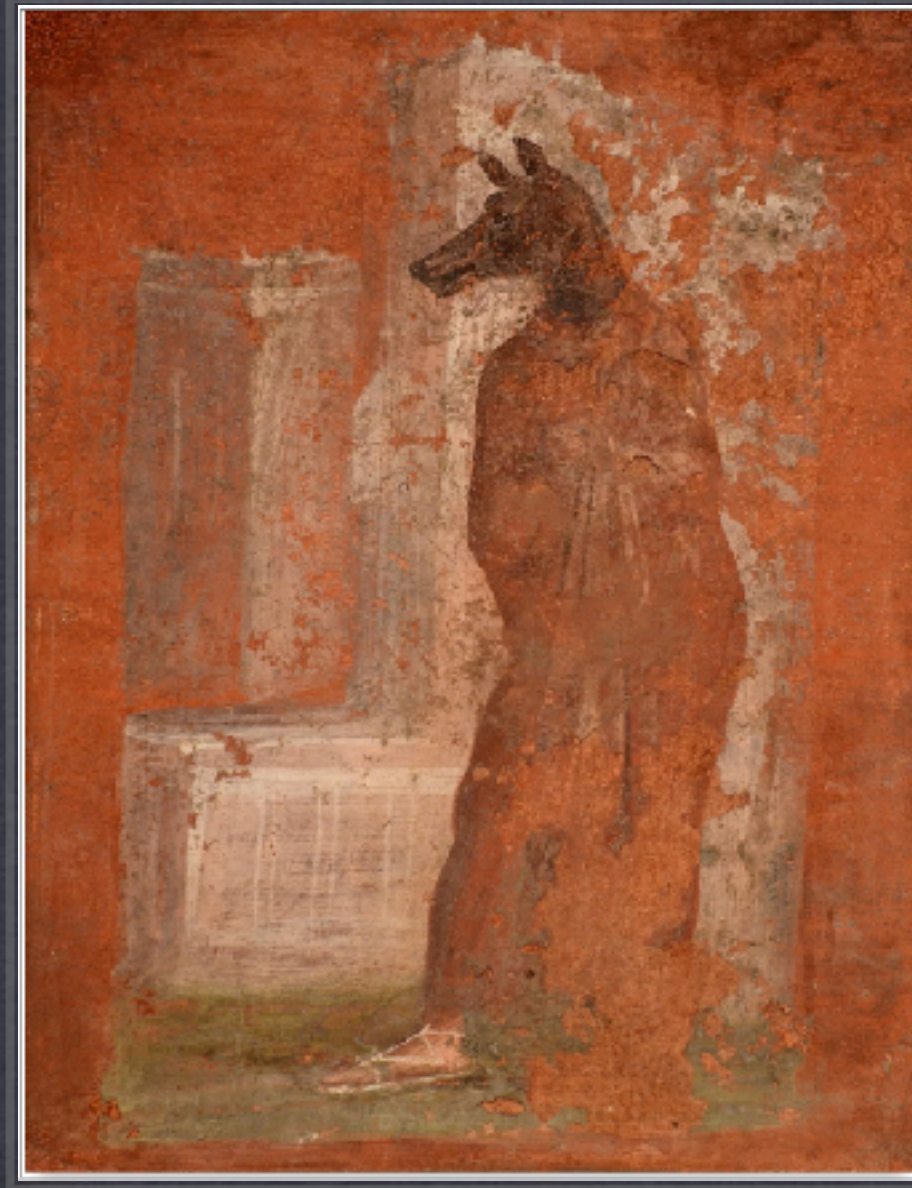




EXPLORING WESTERN PHILOSOPHY (GFHC1073)

DR. MARKUS GEORG THOMAS HEIDINGSFELDER

Exploring Western Philosophy

Teacher, AI, Student Helpers

Teacher: **Dr. Markus Heidingsfelder**, mgt Heidingsfelder@bnbu.edu.cn

AI: **Ms. Lu CHEN**, luchen@bnbu.edu.cn

Student Helpers:

- 1) **GUO Jiayu**, v530024054@mail.bnbu.edu.cn
- 2) **TANG “Ivy” Jinxi**, v530032044@mail.bnbu.edu.cn
- 3) **SUN Feiyang**, v530032043@mail.bnbu.edu.cn>
- 4) **RAMOS “Danny” ALEXANDER**, w6300000140@mail.bnbu.edu.cn

EXPLORING



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WESTERN



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PHILOSOPHY



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EXPLORING

Asking questions, testing boundaries,
refusing to translate the unknown too
quickly into the familiar

WESTERN

A historically changing self-description:
Europe, North America, and the transitions
associated with them

PHILOSOPHY

The practice of examining concepts,
distinctions, and assumptions

Exploring Western Philosophy

What makes it special

- A course called **Exploring Western Philosophy** promises more than a chronological march from Plato to Nietzsche. Its distinctive strength is that *exploring* makes the tradition a terrain of inquiry rather than a museum of correct answers.
- **Exploring** — Students do not merely receive “great ideas”; they test questions, follow conceptual detours, compare answers, and learn where certainty breaks down.
- **Western** — The word names a historical and contested tradition, not a timeless civilizational essence. The course can ask how “the West” constructed itself through philosophy, canon formation, empire, religion, science, and its encounters with what it classified as non-Western. Comparative philosophy starts precisely from the fact that traditions have often been treated as if they developed in isolation.
- **Philosophy** — The subject is not only famous names. It is the practice of making distinctions, examining assumptions, reconstructing arguments, and asking how concepts such as truth, freedom, nature, reason, beauty, self, God, history, and power became thinkable.

Exploring Western Philosophy

What makes it special

- The title leaves room for a course that is simultaneously historical, conceptual, and self-critical.
- It can certainly include the familiar arc – ancient Greek philosophy, medieval theology, early modern rationalism and empiricism, Kant, German idealism, Marx, Nietzsche, phenomenology, existentialism, pragmatism, analytic philosophy, and contemporary critical thought. That is the recognizable historical backbone of a conventional Western-philosophy survey.
- But *exploring* releases the course from the obligation to treat that arc as a triumphal procession. It permits a more interesting question: Why did certain questions become central here, and what did their centrality render invisible?

Exploring Western Philosophy

What makes it special

- For instance:
- When Plato asks what justice is, the course can ask why justice is framed as an abstract universal rather than first as a colonial, gendered, economic, or institutional problem.
- When Descartes says “I think,” the course can ask what sort of self has become imaginable: solitary, interior, rational, and separated from the world.
- When Kant theorizes universal reason, the course can ask how universalism lives together with historical exclusions.
- When Nietzsche attacks morality, the course can ask whether critique liberates us – or simply replaces one certainty with another.
- When contemporary philosophy debates race, gender, technology, climate, AI, or decolonization, the course can ask whether these are applications of old philosophy or transformations of what philosophy itself counts as.

Exploring Western Philosophy

Course Description

Exploring Western Philosophy traces a contested tradition from antiquity to the present while treating philosophy as an activity rather than a catalogue of doctrines. Students examine major thinkers and enduring questions about reality, knowledge, ethics, freedom, beauty, religion, politics, language, and technology. The course also asks how “Western philosophy” became a name for a canon: what it includes, what it excludes, and how its central concepts change when viewed from its historical margins and through encounters with other philosophical traditions. Rather than searching for final answers, the course develops the ability to read closely, reconstruct arguments, identify assumptions, and make one’s own distinctions.

Prologue

Historical Forms

Exploring Western Philosophy

Jullien's formulation addresses a difference in **forms of historicity**.

European philosophy, he argues, tends to stage history as a sequence of ruptures, confrontations, upheavals, and decisive turning points.

The event appears as that which makes a before-and-after difference drastically visible.

Typical figures of the event include revolution, scandal, crisis, war, revelation, and decision.

Silent Transformation

Exploring Western Philosophy

Jullien contrasts this with the notion of **“silent transformation.”**

Transformation does not necessarily occur as a spectacular rupture; it can unfold through gradual shifts in situations, tendencies, potentials, and constellations.

This contrast should not be read as a description of an immutable “Chinese essence.”

Rather, it serves as a heuristic foil against the taken-for-granted character of European conceptual and historical semantics.

Jullien explicitly developed this idea as a critique of the Western fixation on the sudden event.

As an alternative, he proposed the concept of silent transformation, derived from Chinese thought.



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Comparison Without Essentialism

Exploring Western Philosophy

Jullien contrasts modes of thought, not immutable civilizational essences

Classical Chinese traditions often privilege process, correlation, and situational tendency

Major European traditions often foreground origin, being, substance, causality, and subjectivity

This is a historically stabilized asymmetry, not an absolute opposition

Europe also includes process thought: Heraclitus, Spinoza, Hegel, Bergson, Whitehead, systems theory

Chinese traditions also include origins, authority, moral norms, and decisive action

The Yijing offers one powerful way of observing reality: transformation and appropriate connectivity

Propensity

Exploring Western Philosophy

Instead of planning actions in advance, Chinese thought analyzes the “propensity” of a situation and adapts to it. This can be useful for developing a deeper understanding of state governance or conflict avoidance.

In Western-influenced thinking, “opportunism” is often negatively connoted, implying a lack of principles or firmness.

What François Jullien describes—particularly his emphasis on shì (勢) as the “propensity” or disposition of a situation, which one enters into rather than attempts to transform head-on—could, in Western terminology, be described as a form of **strategic opportunism**.

Concept vs. strategic tool

Exploring Western Philosophy

One does not pursue a fixed goal according to a predetermined plan. Instead, one observes the course of events, makes use of existing configurations of forces, reinforces favorable developments, and avoids unnecessary friction. In this sense, it could also be understood as a **philosophy of minimal intervention**, or of the “invisible hand” of governance.

This approach is particularly useful:

in politics, where rigid adherence to principles can often prove counterproductive;

in state governance, where one responds to social dynamics rather than attempting to direct them from above;

in conflict avoidance, where escalation is prevented by balancing tensions rather than confronting them directly.

The question, then, is whether “opportunism” is being used as a moral judgment or as a neutral description of how intelligent strategy operates under complex conditions.

Concept vs. strategic tool

Exploring Western Philosophy

But can one construct a theory without consistent concepts?

From a Western perspective:

No. Theories are based on clearly defined concepts, logical relationships, and consistency.

Philosophy is conceptual work: without stable concepts, there can be no stable argumentation.

→ In this sense, shì would appear too vague and too context-dependent.

Concept vs. strategic tool

Exploring Western Philosophy

From the perspective Jullien reconstructs:

Yes—but it is a different form of theory.

Not theory in the Western sense (deductive, abstract, universal), but rather a form of practical orientation that focuses on processes, effects, and transformations.

Instead of asking, “What is x?” (essentially), one asks: “How does x operate?” or “How does a situation develop?”

→ Theory emerges from the observation of dynamics rather than from the construction of concepts.

Concept vs. strategic tool

Exploring Western Philosophy

What does this imply for theory in general?

Jullien thus challenges the Western assumption that only abstract, conceptually precise theories qualify as serious theory.

He shows that:

there are also theories that operate processually, implicitly, and strategically;

Chinese thought offers a model of situated thinking that is no less rational, but structured differently.

Conclusion: Without consistent concepts, one cannot construct a Western theory—but one can certainly construct a Chinese one. Jullien thus opens our view to alternative forms of theorizing beyond the logocentric tradition of the West.

PRE- SOCRATIC THINKERS (6TH—5TH C. BCE)

ARTIST: EXEKIAS

ARTWORK: VATICAN AMPHORA
(540—530 BCE)



PLATO (427–347 BCE)

ARTIST: LYSIPPOS

ARTWORK: THE SCRAPER
(C. 330 BCE)



ARISTOTLE (384–322 BCE)

ARTIST: PRAXITELES

ARTWORK: HERMES AND THE INFANT
DIONYSOS (C. 340 BCE)



EPICURUS (341–270 BCE)

ARTIST: UNKNOWN (POMPEII FRESCO)



EPICTETUS (50 BC–135)

ARTIST: UNKNOWN (POMPEII FRESCO)



MARCUS AURELIUS (121–180)

ARTIST: UNKNOWN

ARTWORK: THE PORTONACCIO
SARCOPHAGUS (170-180 CE)





AUGUSTINE (354–430)

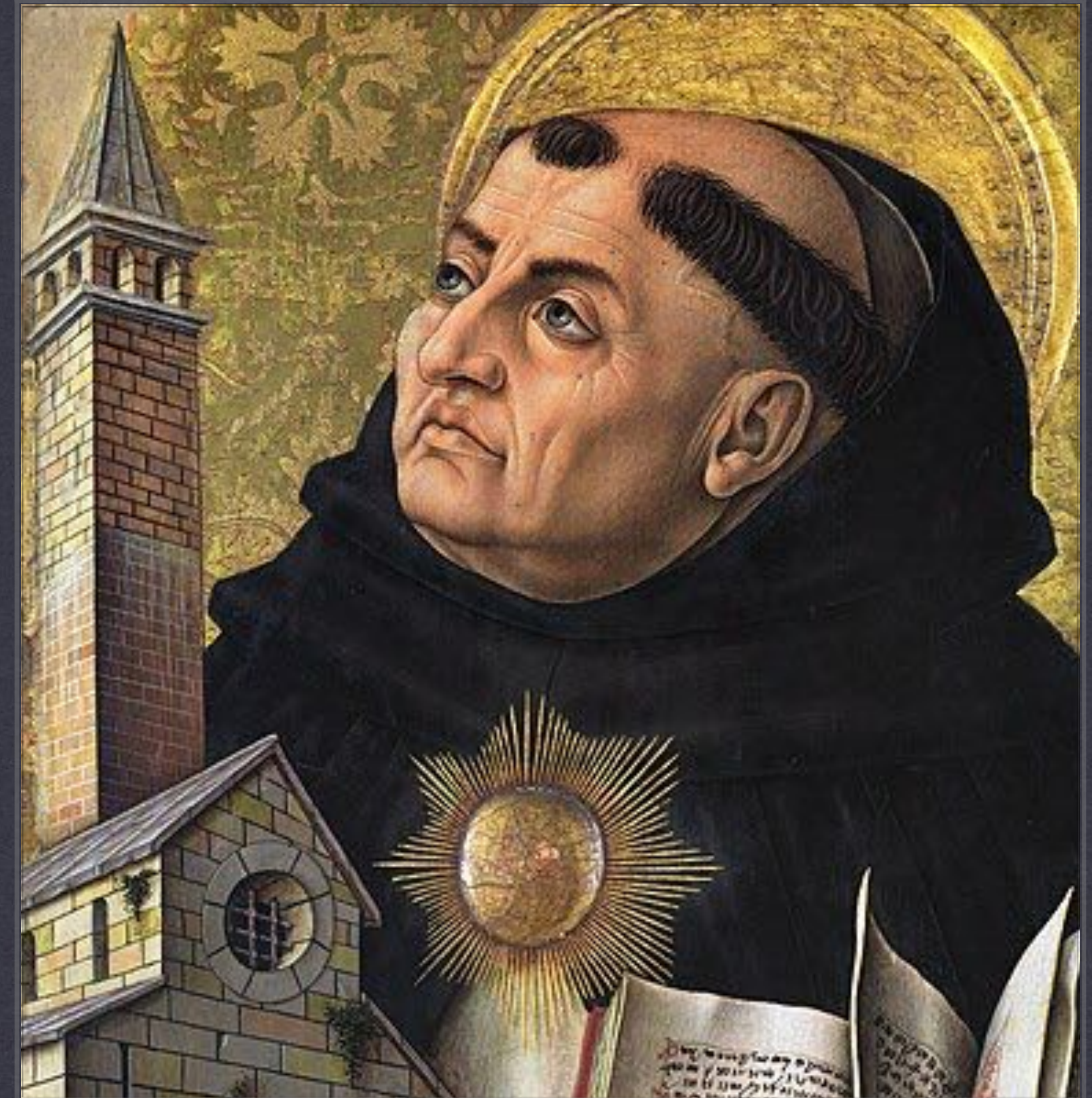
ARTIST: PHILIPPE DE CHAMPAIGNE
ARTWORK: SAINT AUGUSTINE WITH
THE BURNING HEART (C. 1640-1650)



THOMAS AQUINAS (1225–1274)

ARTIST: UNKNOWN

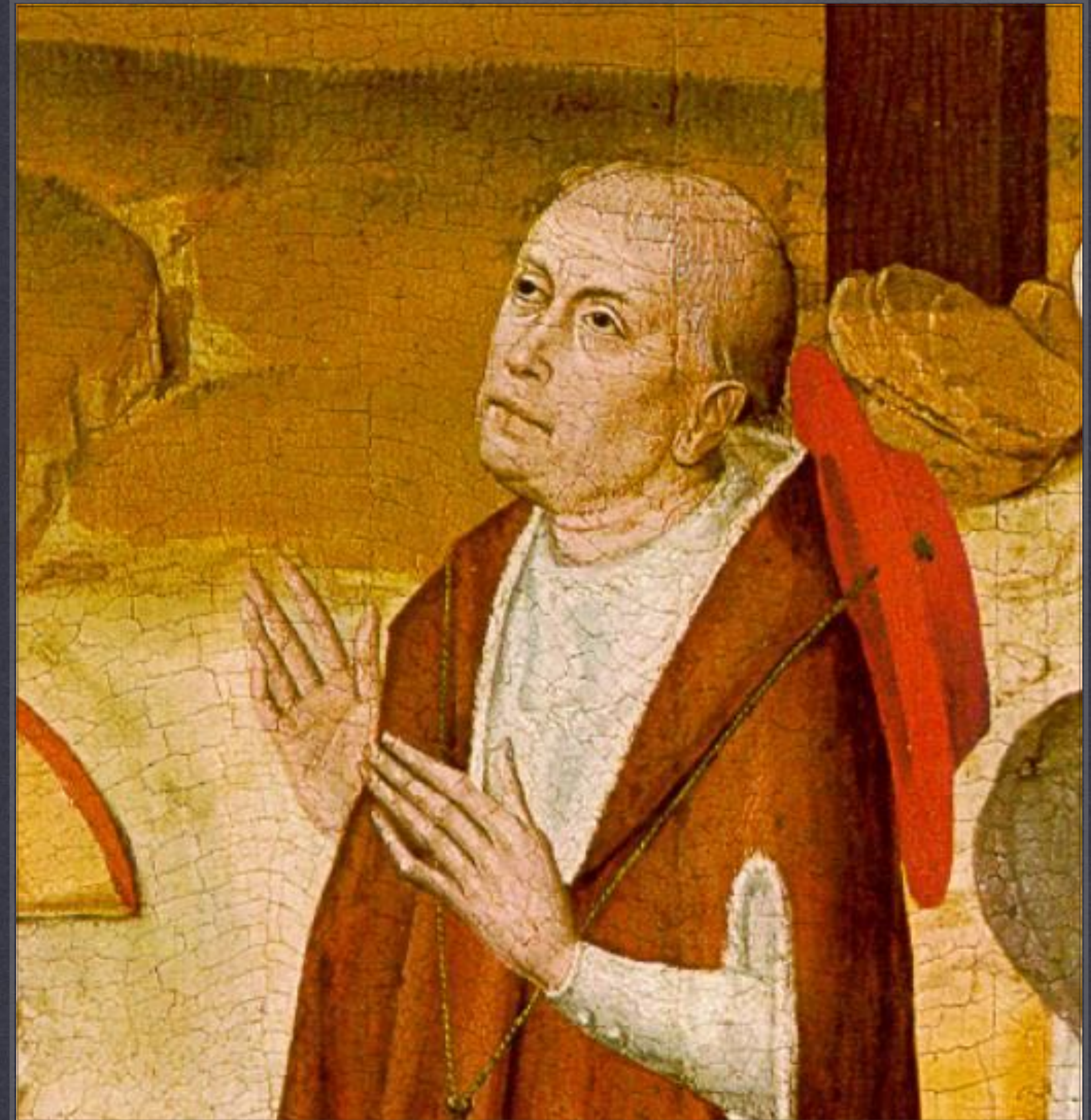
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(15TH CENTURY)



NIKOLAUS VON KUES (1401–1464)

ARTIST: JAN VAN EYCK

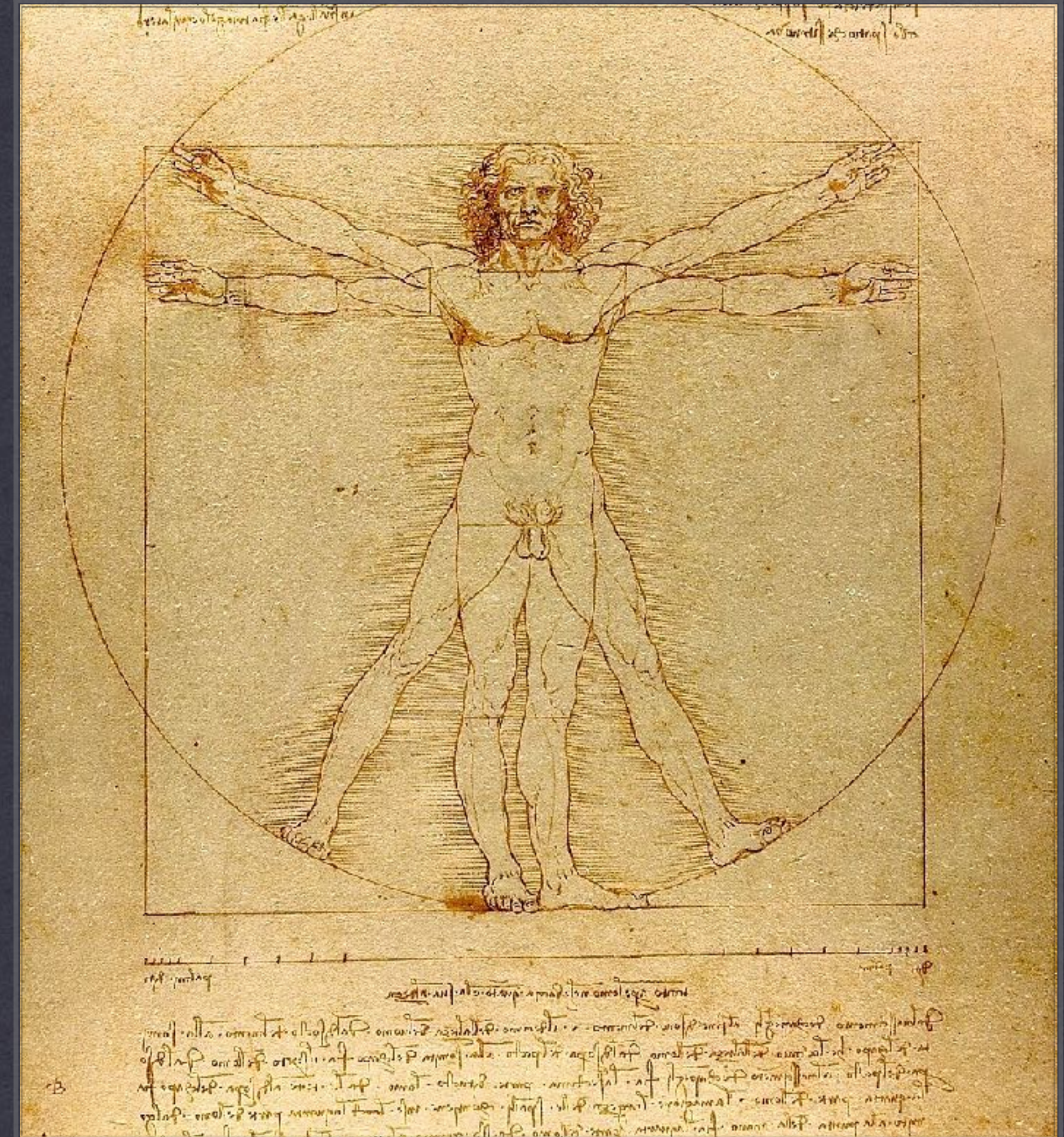
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(1434)



MICHEL DE MONTAIGNE (1533–1592)

ARTIST: LEONARDO DA VINCI

ARTWORK: VITRUVIAN MAN (1490)





RENÉ DESCARTES (1596–1650)

ARTIST: GEORGES DE LA TOUR
ARTWORK: THE PENITENT MAGDALEN
(C. 1640)



THOMAS HOBBS (1588–1679)

ARTIST: DIEGO VELAZQUEZ

ARTWORK: THE SURRENDER OF
BRED A (C. 1634-1635)



JOHN LOCKE (1632–1704)

ARTIST: GODFREY KNELLER

ARTWORK: PORTRAIT OF JOHN
LOCKE (1697)



DAVID HUME (1711–1776)

ARTIST: WILLIAM HOGARTH

ARTWORK: CANVASSING FOR VOTES
(1754)



JEAN- JACQUES ROUSSEAU (1712–1778)

ARTIST: JEAN-BAPTISTE GREUZE

ARTWORK: THE VILLAGE BRIDE
(1761)



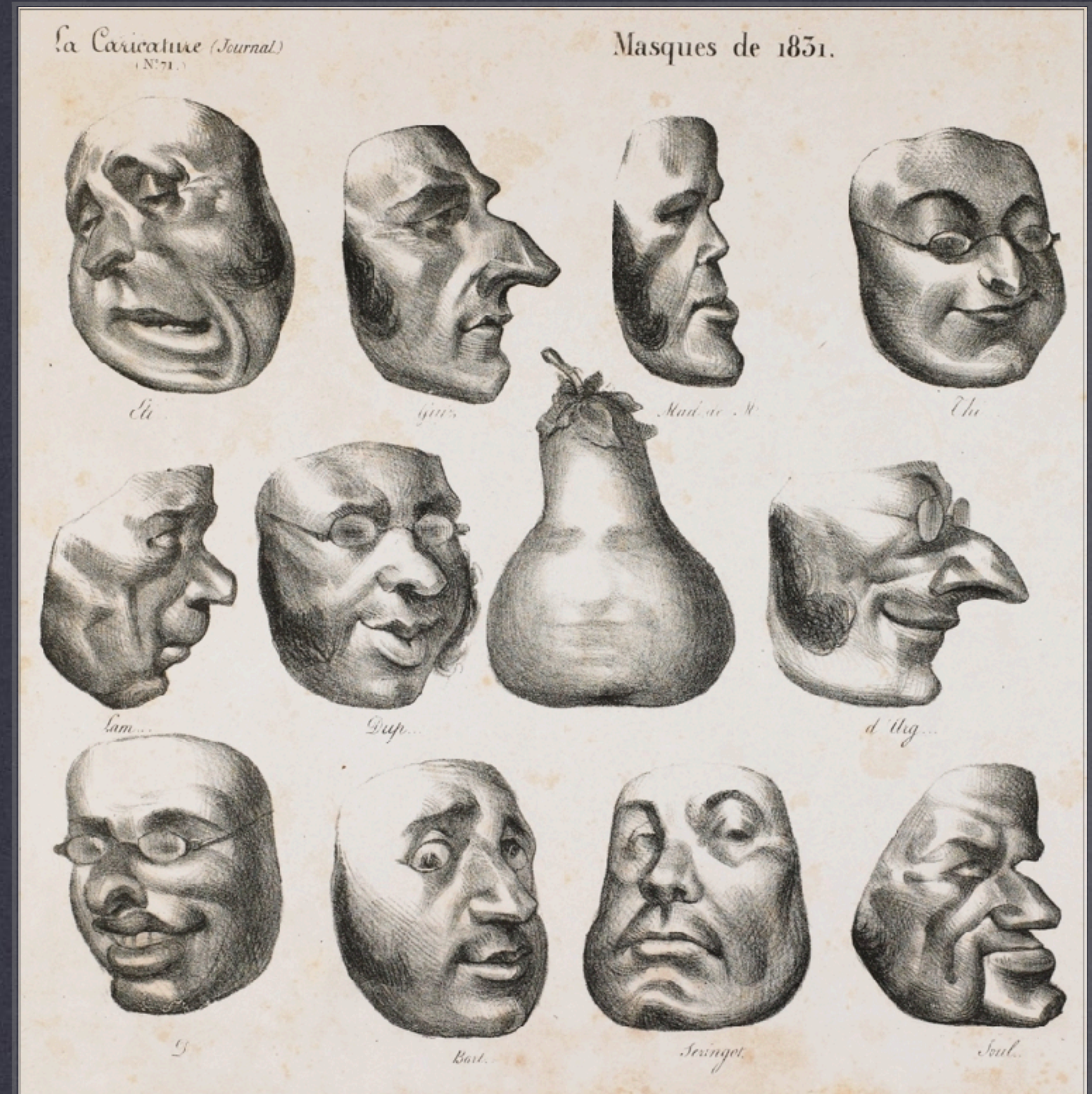
IMMANUEL KANT (1724–1804)

ARTIST: CASPAR DAVID FRIEDRICH
ARTWORK: WANDERER ABOVE THE
SEA OF FOG (1818)



GEORG CHRISTOPH LICHTENBERG (1742–1799)

ARTIST: HONORE DAUMIER
ARTWORK: MASKS (1831)



GEORG WILHELM FRIEDRICH HEGEL (1770–1831)

ARTIST: EUGÈNE DELACROIX
ARTWORK: LIBERTY LEADING THE
PEOPLE (1830)



KARL MARX (1818–1883)

ARTIST: GUSTAVE COURBET

ARTWORK: THE WAVE V(1869)





ERNST MACH (1838–1916)

ARTIST: EGON SCHIELE

ARTWORK: SELF-PORTRAIT WITH
BLACK CLAY VASE AND SPREAD
FINGERS (1911)



WILLIAM JAMES (1842–1910)

ARTIST: CLAUDE MONET

ARTWORK: SUNRISE (1872)



FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE (1844–1900)

ARTIST: VINCENT VAN GOGH

ARTWORK: STARRY NIGHT (1889)



MARTIN HEIDEGGER

(1889–1976)

ARTIST: OTTO DIX

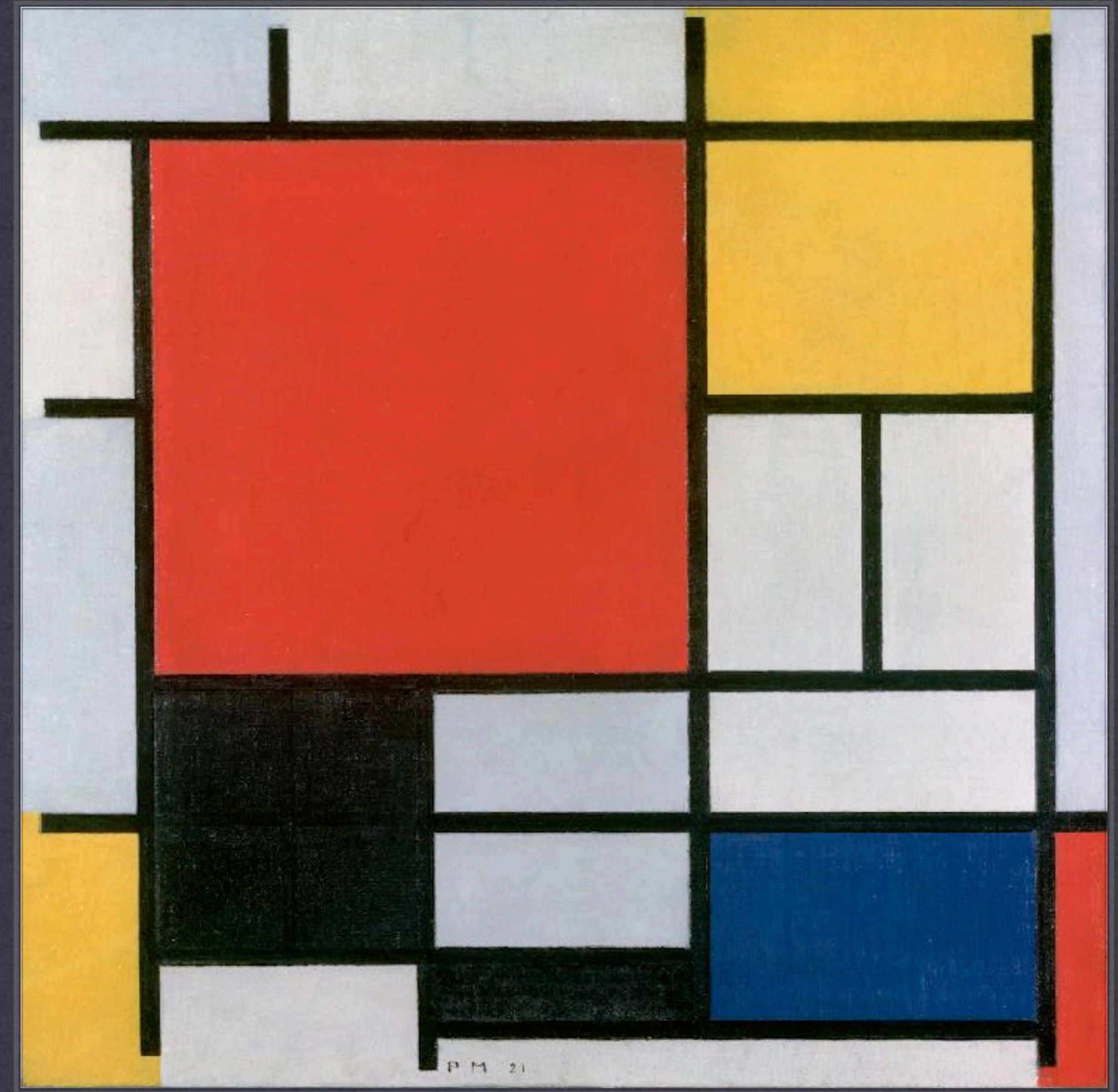
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1916, BAUPAUME (1924)



LUDWIG WITTGENSTEIN (1889–1951)

ARTIST: PIET MONDRIAN

ARTWORK: COMPOSITION WITH RED,
BLUE, AND YELLOW (1930)



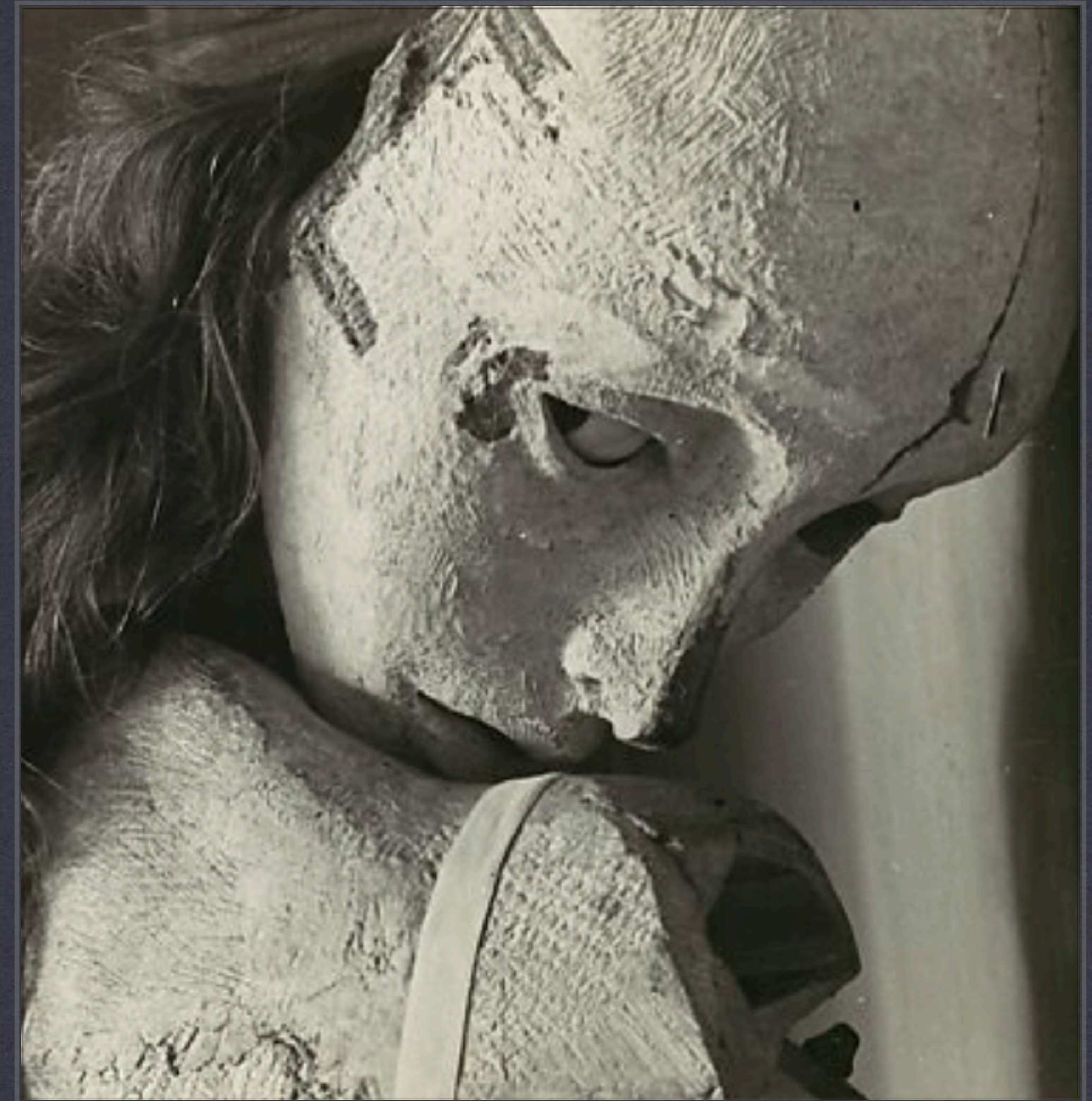
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VELAZQUEZ'S PORTRAIT OF POPE
INNOCENT X (1953)



GEORGES BATAILLE (1897–1962)

ARTIST: HANS BELLMER
ARTWORK: LA POUPEE SERIES
(1930S)



EMMANUEL LEVINAS (1906–1995)

ARTIST: ALBERTO GIACOMETTI
ARTWORK: L'HOMME AU DOIGT (MAN
POINTING, 1947)



JACQUES LACAN (1901–1981)

ARTIST: RENÉ MAGRITTE

ARTWORK: THE FALSE MIRROR
(1928)



MICHEL FOUCAULT (1926–1984)

ARTIST: VELAZQUEZ

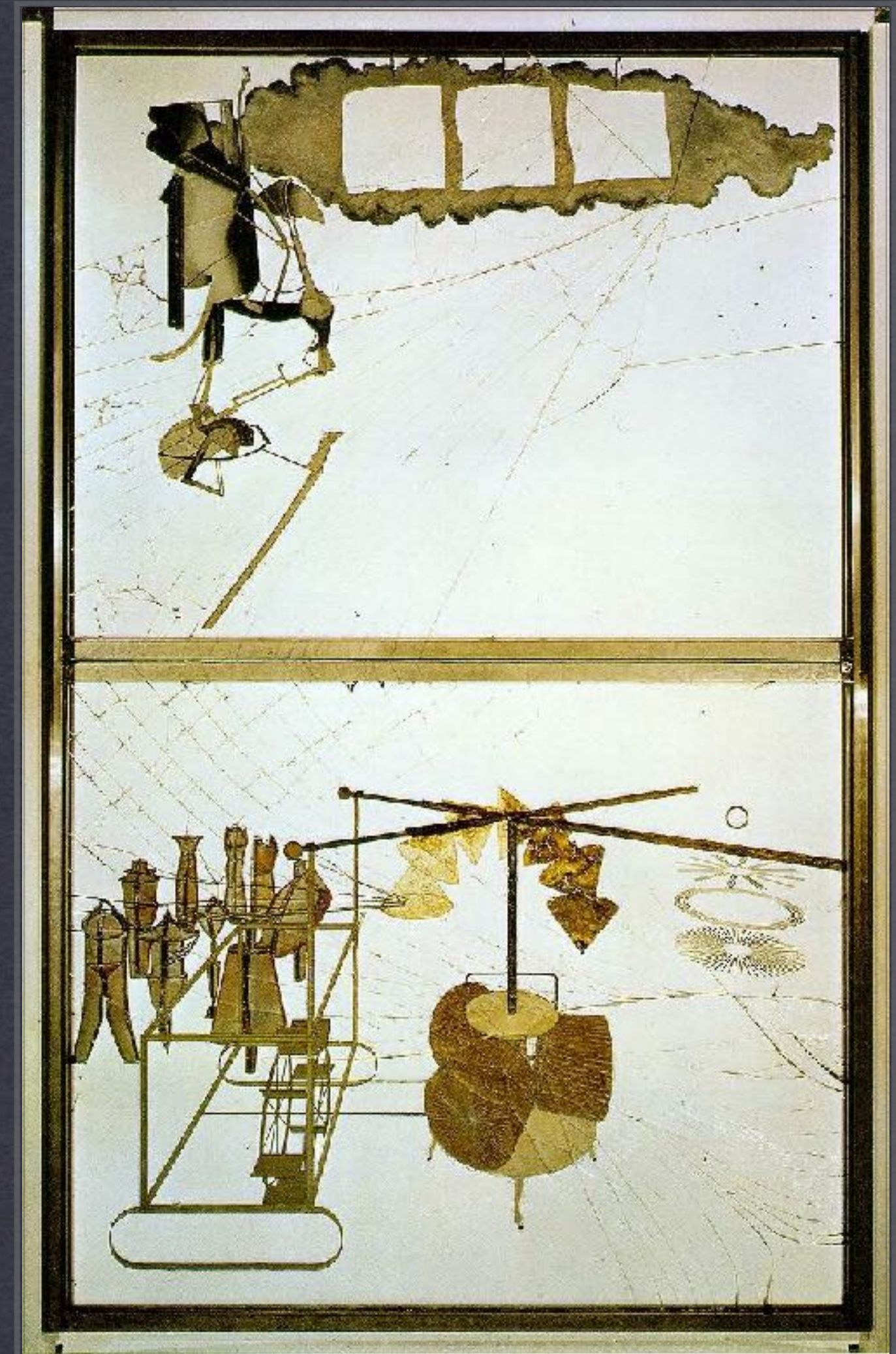
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JACQUES DERRIDA (1930–2004)

ARTIST: MARCEL DUCHAMP

ARTWORK: THE BRIDE STRIPPED
BARE BY HER BACHELORS EVEN (THE
LARGE GLASS, 1915-1923)



GILLES DELEUZE (1925–1995)

ARTIST: FLORIAN MEISENBERG
ARTWORK: THE SMILE OF THE
BEYOND (2021)



AND ...

ANDY WARHOL (1928–1987)

ARTIST: JEFF KOONS

ARTWORK: MICHAEL JACKSON AND
BUBBLES (1988)



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PHILOSOPHY
OF ANDY
WARHOL
(FROM A TO B
& BACK
AGAIN)



BY ANDY
WARHOL